

Session 19: A Flood of Fire

Key Takeaways

- God's angels deliver Lot from destruction, but Lot still wants to choose his own version of safety.
- Later biblical authors invoke Sodom and Gomorrah as icons of God's swift and total judgment on human injustice, immorality, and violence.
- The episode with Lot and his daughters is the origin story of the Moabite and Ammonite nations.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 19:15-22

15 **And just as the sunrise was going up** ,
that the messengers **urged** (ויאיצו) Lot, saying,
"Get up, take **your wife and your two daughters** who are found,
so that **you are not swept away** with the crookedness of **the city** (העיר) !"

16 But he delayed,
and the men grabbed his hand and the hand of **his wife** and the hand of **his two daughters**
—because **the mercy of Yahweh** was upon him—

and they **made him go out** (ויצאהו)
and they rested him outside **the city** (העיר) .

The Man's Speech

17 And it came about as they **made them go out** (הוציא) **to the outside** ,
that he said ,
" **Escape** for your **very being** (נפש) !
Don't stare behind you,
and **don't stand** anywhere in the valley!
Escape **to the mountain** (ההר) , so that **you're not swept away** !"

Lot's Speech

18 **And Lot said to them** ,
"No, **please**, my masters!
19 **Look, please**. Your servant has found **favor** in your eyes,

and you have made great **your loyal love** that you've shown me,
by keeping alive my very being (נפש).

But I am not able to to **escape to the mountain** (ההר),
or else the evil will cling to me, and **I will die**!

20 **Look, please**, this **city** (העיר) is close to **flee** there,
and it is **little** (מצער)!

Please, may I **escape** there,

isn't it **little** (מצער)?

so that my being (נפש) **can live**!"

The Man's Speech

21 **And he said to him**,

"**Look**, I have lifted up your face, even about **this thing**,
so that I won't **overturn** the **city** (העיר) which you spoke of.

22 **Hurry** (מהר), **escape** there,

because I'm not able to do **anything** until you go there!"

This is the reason one calls the name of the **city** (העיר) **"Zoar"** (צוער) [= "little"]

Genesis 19:15-29. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Lot's Escape and Noah's Deliverance

Lot's deliverance from the city is described in language designed to recall Noah's deliverance from the waters of the flood.

Genesis 19:15-26	Genesis 6-9
Gen. 19:15 "Rise, take your wife and your two daughters"	Gen. 6:18 "You will enter the ark, you and your sons and your wife and your son's wives"
Gen. 19:16 "and they took him out and they rested him (וינחהו) outside the city"	Gen. 8:4 "and the ark rested (ותנח) on the mountains of Ararat"
Gen. 19:17 "escape to the mountain!" (ההרה)	
Gen. 19:19 "I have found favor in your eyes ... you have kept my very being alive" (להחיות את נפש)	Gen. 6:8 "Noah (נח) found favor (חן) in the eyes of Yahweh" • Gen. 6:19-20 The animals on the ark are "kept alive" (להחיות)

Lot's Escape and Noah's Deliverance. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Genesis 19:15-26	Genesis 6-9
Gen. 19:24 “Yahweh caused it to rain (המטיר) upon Sodom ... pitch and fire from Yahweh, from the skies”	• Gen. 7:3 “seed will be kept alive (לחיות זרע) on the face of the land” Gen. 7:4 “and about to cause it to rain (המטיר) upon the land”
Gen. 19:29 “Yahweh remembered Avraham, and he sent out Lot from the middle of the overturning when he overturned the cities ...”	Gen. 8:1 “and Elohim remembered Noah and all the living creatures ... with him on the ark”
<i>Lot's Escape and Noah's Deliverance. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).</i>	

Even though it's Avraham who is truly like Noah, his intercession results in Lot being “kept alive” in the flood of judgment. The narrative is showing that the intercession of the righteous one is effective in bringing about the deliverance of the afflicted.

Lot's Deliverance ... With Qualifications

With the story of Lot, we are introduced to a new complication in his character—he doesn't want the deliverance that Yahweh offers, at least not entirely.

Through an elaborate series of wordplays, the narrator portrays Lot as fickle and petty in the moment of his salvation. Instead of accepting the refuge that God has provided, Lot wants to negotiate his own salvation, so the rescue happens on his own terms.

The Man's Speech

17 And it came about as they **made them go out (הוציא)** **to the outside** ,
that he said ,
 “**Escape** for your **very being (נפש)** !
Don't stare behind you,
 and **don't stand** anywhere in the valley!
Escape **to the mountain (ההר)** , so that **you're not swept away** !”

Lot's Speech

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 and you have made great **your loyal love** that you've shown me,
by keeping alive my very being (נפש) .
 But I am not able to to **escape** **to the mountain (ההר)** ,

or else the evil will cling to me, and **I will die**!

20 **Look, please**, this **city (העיר)** is close to **flee** there,
and it is **little (מצער)**!

Please, may I **escape** there,
isn't it **little (מצער)**?

so that my being (נפש) can live!"

The Man's Speech

21 **And he said to him**,
"Look, I have lifted up your face, even about **this thing**,
so that I won't **overturn** the **city (העיר)** which you spoke of.

22 **Hurry (מהר)**, **escape** there,
because I'm not able to do **anything** until you go there!"

This is the reason one calls the name of the **city (העיר)** **"Zoar" (צוער) [= "little"]**

Genesis 19:15-29. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

This wordplay continues into the following scene, but for the moment, let's notice how Lot is depicted as short-sighted and fickle at the very moment God is graciously saving his family's life.

This bears an important resemblance to Cain's negotiation over the deliverance that Yahweh provides after the murder of Abel.

- God provides a "sign" for Cain, but Cain goes out and builds a "city" (עיר) for his own protection (Gen. 4:17).
- Cain builds his city because of his fear that someone will "find" (מצא) him and murder him in revenge for his brother's death (Gen. 4:14).
- The analogy between Cain and Lot accentuates what was implicit in the Cain story: Both characters reject the provision of Yahweh and instead provide their own form of deliverance through a city (עיר).

Zoar and a Pillar of Salt

The curious detail about Lot's wife turning into a pillar of salt (נציב מלח, Gen. 19:26) is explained by its structural alignment with Zoar in Genesis 19:23.

The words "Zoar" and "salt" form the outer frame of the short summary unit of Genesis 19:23-26. Both words are part of a macro frame around all of chapters 12-19. Chapters 14 and 19 form the "flood-crescendo" of their respective units.

- Chapter 14 brings Genesis 12-14 to its climax, and it revolves around Avraham's deliverance of Lot.
- Chapter 19 brings Genesis 18-19 to its climax, and it revolves around Avraham's deliverance of Lot, again!

In both stories, the escaped remnant flees to the mountains (Gen. 14:10, 19:17), while the unbelieving stay in the valley and fall into pits of tar near the salt sea and Zoar (Gen. 14:2-3, 8-10). The design parallel of "Zoar"

and “salt” here in Genesis 19:23, 26 places Lot’s wife in the same category as the fleeing kings of Sodom and Gomorroah, who fall into pits of tar. Only here she is turned into something similar above ground, a “pillar of salt.”

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 19:27-29

27 And Avraham rose **early in the morning**,
to the place where he had stood before the face of Yahweh,

28 and he looked down
upon the face of **Sodom and over Gomorrah**,
and upon **all** the face of the land of **the valley**,
and he saw, and look, **the smoke** of the land went up like **the smoke of a furnace**.

29 And it came about when Yahweh **caused the ruin** of **the cities (העיר)** of **the valley**,
that he remembered **Avraham**,
and he sent Lot out from the middle of **the overturning**,
when he **overturned** the **cities (העיר)**,
in which Lot had been **dwelling**.

Genesis 19:15-29. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Avraham, the Righteous Intercessor

Avraham’s role in Lot’s deliverence echoes a theme from the flood narrative; those "with" Noah benefitted from his righteous standing before God and were delivered along "with him."

Genesis 6:18-19 Instructor’s Translation

18 ... Go into the ark, you and your sons and your wife and the wives of your sons **with you**¹⁹ and of every living thing of all flesh, two of everything, you will make go into the ark to keep them alive **with you**.

Genesis 7:1 Instructor’s Translation

Enter, **you** and all your house into the ark, for **you** I have seen as righteous before me in this generation.

Genesis 7:7 Instructor’s Translation

And he entered, **Noah** and his sons and his wife and his wives sons **with him**, into the ark ...

Genesis 7:23 Instructor’s Translation

And everything was wiped out from the land, but Noah was left remaining, and those **with him** in the ark.

Genesis 8:1 Instructor’s Translation

And *Elohim* remembered Noah and all the living things and all the creatures who were **with him** in the ark ...

The narrative clearly highlights Noah's status as the person God deals with and delivers from the flood. But Noah's family and the creatures with him benefit from his righteous status before God, so they too are saved from the flood.

This is precisely the theme at work in the Avraham and Lot story. Avraham is the chosen one, and he was already delivered from the flood of human violence back in [chapter 14](#). Immediately after that, his trust in God was reckoned to him as right-standing before God, so his intercession on behalf of Lot is effective.

Sodom and Gomorrah and the Flood: Icons of Divine Justice

Throughout the Bible, the ruin of Sodom and Gomorrah is a common icon for a whole bundle of concepts involving human evil, the ruin of the land, and the resulting flood of divine judgment. The story itself is referenced throughout the Hebrew Bible.

Deuteronomy 29:23-28 NIV

²³ The whole land will be a **burning waste of salt and sulfur**—nothing planted, nothing sprouting, **no vegetation** growing on it. It will be like the **destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah**, Admah and Zeboyim, which the LORD overthrew in fierce anger. ²⁴ All the nations will ask: “Why has the LORD done this to this land? Why this fierce, burning anger?” ²⁵ And the answer will be: “It is because this people abandoned the covenant of the LORD, the God of their ancestors, the covenant he made with them when he brought them out of Egypt. ²⁶ They went off and worshiped other gods and bowed down to them, gods they did not know, gods he had not given them. ²⁷ Therefore the LORD’s anger burned against this land, so that **he brought on it all the curses written in this book**. ²⁸ In furious anger and in great wrath the LORD uprooted them from their land and thrust them into another land, as it is now.”

Deuteronomy 32:32-33 NIV

³² Their vine comes from **the vine of Sodom and from the fields of Gomorrah**. Their grapes are filled with poison, and their clusters with bitterness. ³³ Their wine is the venom of **serpents**, the deadly poison of cobras.

Isaiah 1:9-10 NIV

⁹ Unless the LORD Almighty had left us some **survivors**, we would have become like **Sodom**, we would have been like **Gomorrah**. ¹⁰ Hear the word of the LORD, you rulers of **Sodom**; listen to the instruction of our God, you people of **Gomorrah**!

Isaiah 3:8-9 NIV

⁸ Jerusalem staggers, Judah is falling; their words and deeds are against the LORD, defying his glorious presence. ⁹ The look on their faces testifies against them; **they parade their sin like Sodom**; they do not hide it. Woe to them! They have brought disaster upon themselves.

Isaiah 13:19-20 NIV

¹⁹ **Babylon**, the jewel of kingdoms, the pride and glory of the Babylonians, **will be overthrown by God like Sodom and Gomorrah**. ²⁰ She will never be inhabited or lived in through all generations; there no nomads will pitch their tents, there no shepherds will rest their flocks.

Jeremiah 23:14 NIV

And among the prophets of Jerusalem I have seen something horrible: They commit adultery and live a lie. They strengthen the hands of evildoers, so that not one of them turns from their wickedness. **They are all like Sodom to me; the people of Jerusalem are like Gomorrah.**

Jeremiah 49:17-18 NIV

¹⁷ “**Edom** will become an object of horror; all who pass by will be appalled and will scoff because of all its wounds. ¹⁸ As **Sodom and Gomorrah were overthrown**, along with their neighboring towns,” says the LORD, “so no one will live there; no people will dwell in it.”

Amos 4:11-12 NIV

¹¹ “I overthrew some of you as **I overthrew Sodom and Gomorrah**. You were like a burning stick snatched from the fire, yet you have not returned to me,” declares the LORD. ¹² “Therefore this is what I will do to you, Israel, and because I will do this to you, Israel, prepare to meet your God.”

Zephaniah 2:9 NIV

Therefore, as surely as I live,” declares the LORD Almighty, the God of Israel, “**surely Moab will become like Sodom, the Ammonites like Gomorrah**—a place of weeds and salt pits, a wasteland forever. The remnant of my people will plunder them; the survivors of my nation will inherit their land.”

Lamentations 4:6 NIV

The punishment of my people is greater than that of Sodom, which was overthrown in a moment without a hand turned to help her.

Corruption, Judgment, and the Righteous Remnant

In [Genesis 6-9](#) and [19](#), we are introduced to a network of overlapping terms that will echo throughout the rest of the biblical narrative.

The Vocabulary of Human Corruption

- violence (חמס)
- sexual abuse
- the outcry (זעקה/צעקה)

The Vocabulary of Judgment

- ruin (השחית/שחת)
- sweep away (ספה)
- wipe out (מחה)

- die (מות)
- expire (גוע)
- rain/flood waters (המטיר/מים)

The Vocabulary of the Righteous Remnant

- Noah / rest / comfort (נח/נוח/נחם)
- remain / remnant (נשאר/שאר)
- escape / refugee (מלט/המלט)
- flee (נוס)
- images of refuge: mountain (הר) / cave (מערה) / ark (תבה) / house (הבית) / shadow (צל)
- life / to keep alive (חי/החיה)

All of these terms and thematic motifs will be drawn upon and developed throughout the narrative. This verbal cohesion of the flood with Sodom and Gomorrah also explains why later Jews in the Second Temple period drew such close connections between these stories.

Jude 1:5-7 NIV

⁵ Though you already know all this, I want to remind you that the Lord at one time delivered his people out of Egypt, but later destroyed those who did not believe. ⁶ **And the angels who did not keep their positions of authority but abandoned their proper dwelling**—these he has kept in darkness, bound with everlasting chains for judgment on the great Day. ⁷ **In a similar way, Sodom and Gomorrah and the surrounding towns gave themselves up to sexual immorality and perversion.** They serve as an example of those who suffer the punishment of eternal fire.

2 Peter 2:4-9 NIV

⁴ For **if God did not spare angels when they sinned**, but sent them to hell, putting them in chains of darkness to be held for judgment; ⁵ **if he did not spare the ancient world when he brought the flood** on its ungodly people, but protected Noah, a preacher of righteousness, and seven others; ⁶ **if he condemned the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah by burning them to ashes**, and made them an example of what is going to happen to the ungodly; ⁷ and if he rescued Lot, a righteous man, who was distressed by the depraved conduct of the lawless ⁸ (for that righteous man, living among them day after day, was tormented in his righteous soul by the lawless deeds he saw and heard)— ⁹ if this is so, then the Lord knows how to rescue the godly from trials and to hold the unrighteous for punishment on the day of judgment.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 19:30-38

- a ³⁰ And Lot went up from **Zoar (צוער)**,
 b and he **dwelt** on the mountain,
 c and **his two daughters** with him,
 a' because he was afraid of **dwelling** in **Zoar (צוער)**,
 b' and he **dwelt** in a **cave (מערה)**,

c' he and **his two daughters** .

- A 31 **And the firstborn said to the little one (צעירה)**,
"Our father is old,
B and there is no man in the land to come over us,
as is the way of all the land.
32 **Come, let's make our father drink wine,**
C **and let's lie with him,**
and we will make seed (זרע) come to life from our father."
33 **And they made their father drink wine in that night,**
D **and the firstborn went**
and she laid with her father,
and he did not know when she laid down or when she got up.

- A' 34 And it came about on the next day,
that the firstborn said to the little one (צעירה),
B' **"Look, I laid last night with my father.**
Let's make him drink wine also tonight,
C' **and go, lie with him,**
so we can make seed (זרע) come to life from our father."
35 **And they again made their father drink wine on that night,**
D' **and the little one (צעירה) got up**
and she laid with her father ,
and he did not know when she laid down and when she got up.

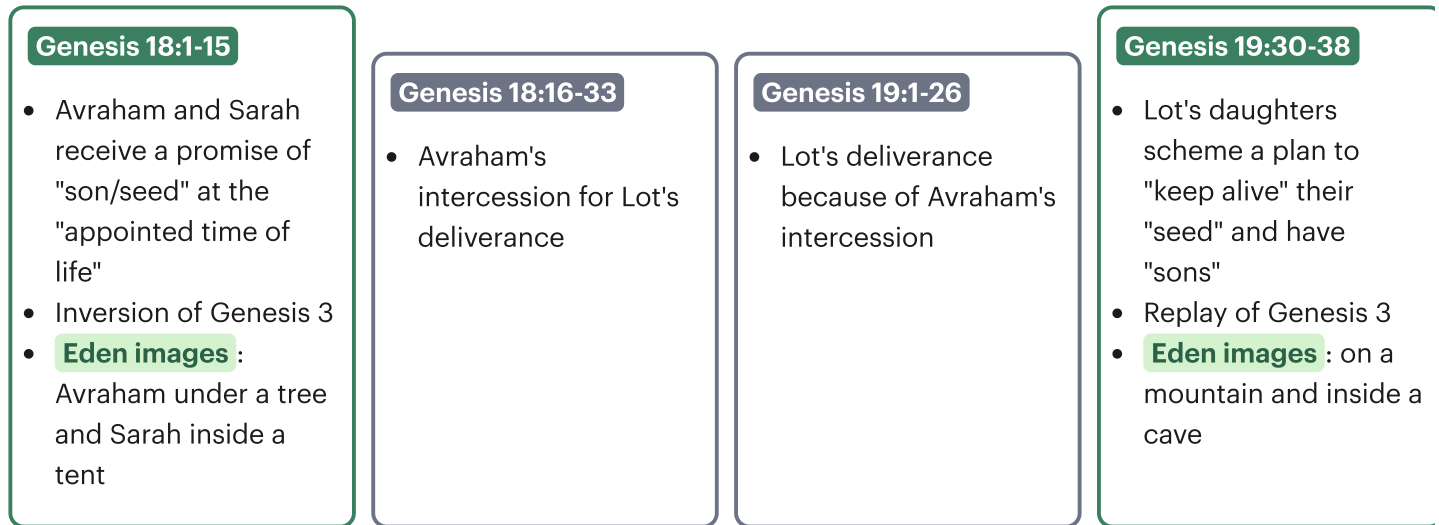
- 36 And the **two daughters of Lot** became pregnant by **their father** .
a 37 And the **firstborn** gave birth to a son,
b and she called his name "Moab,"
c he is the father of Moab until this day.
a' 38 And the **little one (צעירה)**, she also gave birth to a son,
b' and she called his name "Ammon,"
c' he is the father of the sons of Ammon until this day.

Genesis 19:30-38. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

The Blessing of Seed Distorted

This strange and disturbing story seems an odd conclusion to the dramatic narrative epic of Abraham's intercession and Lot's deliverance. The scene's significance is only clarified when it's seen in light of its placement in the design of Genesis 18:1-19:38 and in light of its relationship to the story of Noah and Ham after the flood.

The Macro Design of Genesis 18-19



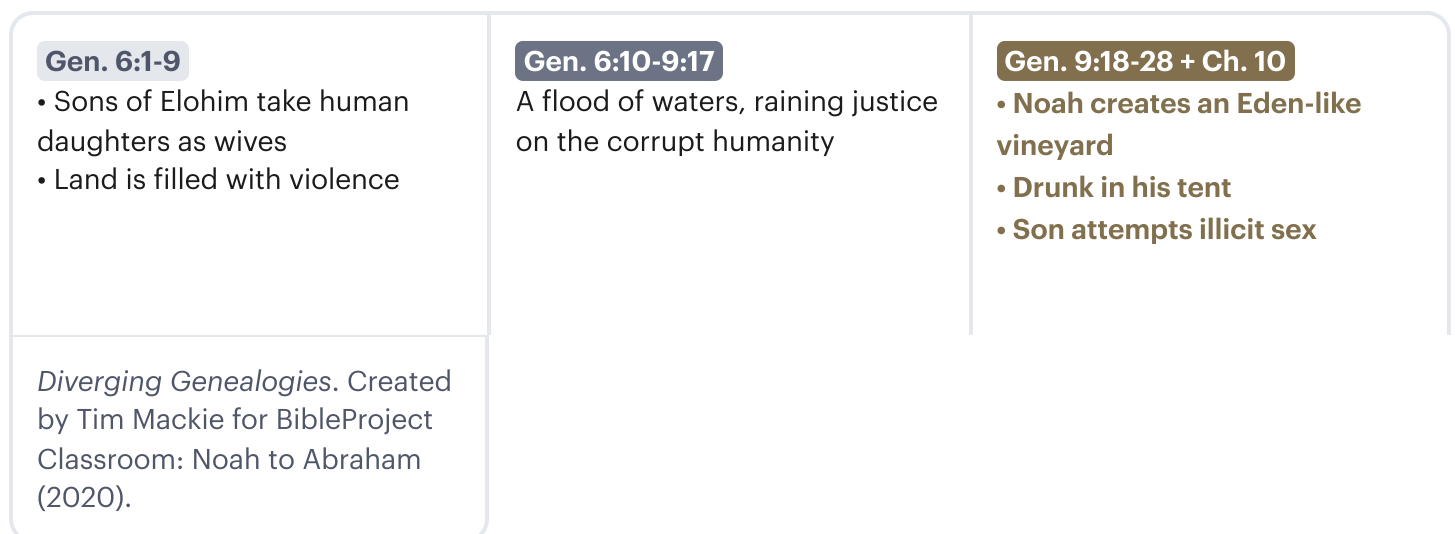
Genesis 18:1-19:38 (Detailed). Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

The opening and closing stories of Genesis chapters 18-19 are about the survival of the future seed. After the flood of judgment and mercy on Avraham in Genesis 17, God's promise of a future seed/son remains in Genesis 18:1-15. The promise is given in two Eden spots, under a tree and inside a tent.

The closing story of Lot's deliverance from the flood of judgment on Sodom is also about the survival of the future seed. But here, the daughters turn their legitimate concern into a distorted scheme of incest: They will deceive their father with wine in order to keep seed alive (Gen. 19:32, 34).

Noah and Ham, Lot and His Daughters

The significance of the story of Lot and his daughters is also illuminated by its placement as a hinge piece between the Sodom story and the next part of the Avraham story. The narrative about Lot's deliverance from Sodom because of Avraham's intercession came to a close in 19:27-29, as Avraham looks down. The story in Genesis 19:30-38, while about Lot, actually stands as a distinct episode after the ruin of Sodom. In this way, the story is precisely aligned with the story of Noah and Ham after the flood.



		resulting in birth of the Canaanites
Gen. 19:1-14 Lot protects angels by offering his daughters to the men of Sodom for sexual violence	Gen. 19:15-29 A flood of justice, raining fire on the corrupt human city	Gen. 19:30-38 • Lot finds an Eden-like cave • Drunk in the cave • Daughters attempt illicit sex resulting in the birth of Moabites and Ammonites
<i>Diverging Genealogies. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).</i>		

Comparing the two stories highlights multiple features of Lot’s story.

Noah’s folly was not in cultivating a vineyard but in drinking so much that he became vulnerable to his son’s predatory desires.

Lot’s folly wasn’t in accepting the counsel of the angels and the deliverance that they sought to provide. Rather, his folly was in his desire to secure his own deliverance by going to a “little” city (Zoar). His folly creates further problems. For some unstated reason, Lot and his daughters leave Zoar and go up to the eastern hills, where his choice of a cave isolates their entire family. It’s precisely that isolation that leads the daughters to think that they’re the only people left in the region and that they need to come up with their own plan to “keep seed alive” (Gen. 19:32, 34).

In both cases, the result of the father’s folly and the children’s inappropriate behavior is the birth of sons who will become hostile to Avraham’s descendants for the rest of the Hebrew Bible.

Moab, Ammon, and Sibling Rivalry

The births of Moab and Ammon, whose descendants will form the kingdoms on the east side of the Jordan, become the mirror image of the Canaanites on the west side of the Jordan. However, unlike the Canaanites who came under the curse of Noah (Gen. 9:25-27), the Moabites and Ammonites are, like Yishmael, family with Avraham (they’re his great-nephews). So their hostility is open to resolution and perhaps even reconciliation.

The Hostility of Moab and Ammon

- Moab will conspire with Midian (sons of Qeturah) to curse the Israelites as they wander in the wilderness (Num. 22-24).
- Moabite women seduce Israelite men into worshipping their gods (Num. 25).
- Eglon the king of Moab allies with Ammon to oppress Israel (Judg. 3:12-14).

- Moabites and Ammonites spar with the Israelites in the days of Jephthah (Judg. 10:6-8), King Saul (1 Sam. 11:11, 12:12, 14:47), David (2 Sam. 8:2, 12), Ahab (2 Kgs. 1:1), Elisha (2 Kgs. 3).

The Future Reconciliation of Moab and Ammon

- The Moabite Ruth is integrated into the lineage of Abraham, Judah, David, and Jesus Messiah!
- David forms a peaceful alliance with Moab and even leaves his parents there for safety from Saul (1 Sam. 22:4).
- Jeremiah anticipates the eventual restoration of Moab (Jer. 48:47) and Ammon (Jer. 49:6).

Cain, Lot, and Lot's Daughters

Notice how the unit of Genesis 19:17-22, which relates how Lot was forced outside of Sodom by the angels, concludes with an etiology about the naming of Zoar (Gen. 19:22). This entire unit is about how God shows mercy to Lot and directs him to flee to the mountains (ההרה המלט, Gen. 19:17). But Lot would rather flee to a city and dwell there.

This entire scene recalls the story of Cain, when God shows mercy to him after he murders his brother (Gen. 4:9-17). God promises to protect Cain by placing a sign upon him, but Cain immediately goes into exile and builds for himself his own form of protection, a city (עיר), which he calls by the name of his son (שם + קרא, Gen. 4:17).

This final unit of Genesis 19:17-22 creatively develops this theme, as Lot is shown the “mercy of Yahweh” (חמלת יהוה, Gen. 19:16). Instead of accepting Yahweh’s deliverance, he negotiates his own plan to be spared in a city (עיר), the name of which is subject to various wordplays (צוער, מצער). The unit concludes with the naming of the city: “So then, one calls the name of the city Zoar” (19:22).

Notice how this unit of Genesis 19:17-22 acts as a frame to the bonus units about Lot’s daughters (Gen. 19:30-38). It provides a mirror episode of Lot’s hesitation and negotiations with the angels while also echoing the story of Noah and Ham after the flood.

Lot is afraid to stay in Zoar, so he ends up living in the mountains after all (Gen. 19:30, 17), specifically, in a cave (מערה), a wordplay on “little” (מצער) and “nakedness” (ערום) and “shrewd” (ערום) from the Eden narrative (Gen. 2:25, 3:1).

Lot’s firstborn and “little one” (צעירה) devise their own plan to “keep alive their seed” (נחיה ... זרע, 19:32, 34), even though God has already done so, just as he did for Noah’s family (Gen. 7:20). Just as Lot proposed his own plan that led to little Zoar (צוער, מצער), so now his daughters propose their own plan to save their seed in a cave (מערה, זרע).

In both cases, the characters reflect an ignorance of Yahweh’s deliverance and so develop their own plan instead, leading to the naming of a city (Zoar), and to the birth and naming of two sons (Moab and Ammon) who will come to cause trouble for Abraham’s descendants.

Reflection Question

Ammon and Moab are born from a string of tragic and disturbing events. What role do their descendants play in the biblical drama?



Module 5: Abraham Surrenders His Sons

SESSIONS 20-24

Abraham runs out of schemes and reaches the point of surrender. As his plans result in the division of his family, God leads Abraham to the ultimate test.